
Living Abroad Helped Me Realize Some of the Best Qualities of Americans

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Whenever I tell people I'm from the U.S. these days, I feel obligated to tack on an "unfortunately." My country has a [terrible reputation](#) right now, and for good reason. Suffice it to say, it's hard to be proud to be an American, especially as our president ramps up the celebration for the country's 250th birthday (and [co-opts it for himself](#)).

I've been lucky to be able to escape some of it by [living in Amsterdam](#) for the past two years. I've gotten accustomed to the habits and lifestyle, I've started learning the language, and I actually appreciate the somewhat brutal honesty for which Dutch people are known.

But there are noticeable cultural differences. An American friend who has lived here for years puts it well: The Dutch directness can be cold, but once you crack them, the interactions are more genuine. They don't like small talk and are all about efficiency. Recently, when trying to practice Dutch with a local, I was told, "It's nice that you want to practice, but it takes lots of energy to speak with you." Ouch.

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Meanwhile, Americans are perceived as nice, yes, but fake. We're also overbearingly loud: These days, I can easily identify an American in a room just by how noisy they are. Whenever I see a crowd of obnoxious American visitors, I try not to affiliate with them.

There are times I break my rule, though. If I notice someone who needs help or just has a good vibe, I will approach. I still like to ask where they're from, as I've offended too many Canadians by assuming, but usually it's not a shock when they say the U.S.

Recently, I met someone who had also moved here from D.C., my hometown. We immediately started discussing the elephant in the room and how both of us had been able to leave before Trump got elected. She had spent 10 years in the district and had been working for the U.S. Agency for International Development before she moved to the Netherlands, a year or so prior to its dismantling. "I felt lucky, like I was getting off at the last port before the *Titanic* set sail," she joked.

It also turned out that we've been living two blocks from each other. We made plans to get coffee and exchanged numbers, and I walked up my three flights of steep Dutch stairs, buzzing with joy.

This brief run-in made me pause for a moment to think through the particular ache of homesickness the interaction had prompted. It made me ponder my love for my country or, rather, made me realize how much I appreciate my fellow Americans. I love that we may start a conversation with you in line for coffee. We'll compliment the outfits of random passersby. We can also be incredibly welcoming, known to invite you to things even if we don't fully know you. Case in point: I recently mentioned

that my uncle was coming into town and wanted to take me and a few friends out to dinner, to which my German boyfriend said, “That’s so American.” (That tends to be a common refrain in our relationship.)

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Sure, some of the Americans I may be meeting here are a specific subset of the country, and [many have left](#) because they feel similarly to me about the current state of things. I sometimes joke that we’re the defectors. But whenever I do run into other Americans, like my neighbor, I feel a sense of comfort. When I spoke to my apparent neighbor, it was just so easy to talk and commiserate about the state of our former city. She understood my conflicting emotions.

I’ve had similarly validating and positive interactions with other Americans living here—the main emotion, which I realize feels uniquely American-interaction coded, is joy. Ali, another American friend here, agreed with the criticisms that Americans aren’t always genuine; there’s some truth to the fakeness stereotype. We love to schmooze, and sometimes we make empty promises about grabbing a drink or coffee (though I did see my neighbor for coffee, thank you very much). But this fakeness can also intersect with enthusiasm, which is what I miss most about Americans. Maybe it’s because they’re my longtime friends, family, and co-workers, but in the U.S. I had—and still have—so many people who celebrate the small wins and joys of life with me.

But I don’t think it’s just due to the length of those relationships. I think it’s cultural. Here, I’ve repeatedly had times when I have exciting news I want to share with my inner circle, but I don’t get the response I’m used to back in the U.S. Ali puts it well: They don’t “gas you up” in the same way. I know that it doesn’t mean they’re not interested—my boyfriend is one of my biggest supporters—but sometimes I’m looking for an enthusiastic reaction. I also *do* admire that emotional resilience that he and many other European friends of mine possess. Their even keel pays off when things are big in the negative direction; they seem more functional with their emotions than I am. I can’t fully attribute that solely to my Americanness, but that’s definitely part of it.

A week after I met my neighbor, I ran into an American couple, this time at a cafe in Maastricht.

They had an empty chair at their table, and I asked to sit, pretty sure they were members of the same tribe. My suspicions were correct. They were from the other Washington, on an island outside Seattle. As I ate my strawberry rhubarb pie, we talked as if we had all come to eat together. We chatted about the fear of Immigration and Customs Enforcement in Seattle, their desire to retire in France or the Netherlands, and what it was like to live here. It was another moment of American friendliness, a genuine connection that felt like home.

I don't normally celebrate the Fourth of July. And this year is no exception. But this time I will appreciate the company: I'll be spending it backpacking with a fellow American: my mom.

Update, July 5, 2026: A quote in this article has been updated to better reflect a former USAID worker's sentiments.

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